

Family Reguliidae

# Kinglets and goldcrests

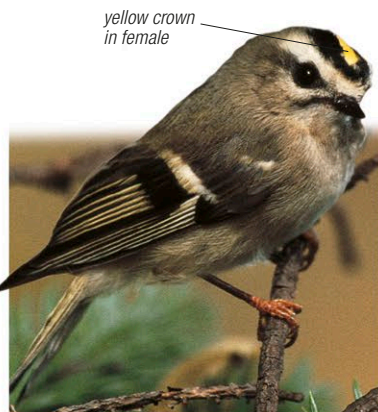
Length 3¼–4¼ in (8–11 cm)

Species 6



These small warblerlike birds occur in the Northern Hemisphere, where they are adapted for living and feeding in coniferous forests: they have long

claws and grooved feet for grasping needle-leaved twigs and branches as they continually search for minute insect food to fuel their tiny bodies. They get their name from their fiery crown stripe—the feathers of which are erected in display.



**GOLDEN-CROWNED KINGLET**  
The smallest North American kinglet at 3¼–4¼ in (8–11 cm) long, *Regulus satrapa* can withstand the harsh northern winter in the pine woods of New England. It breeds in spruce trees, in a dainty, globelike nest of moss and feathers under a branch. The female lays 8–10 tiny whitish eggs.

Family Sittidae

# Nuthatches

Length 10–20 cm (4–8 in)

Species 28



Birds in this family, found in North and Central America, Europe, North Africa, and Asia, spend their whole life in trees, inching up or down trunks and branches with equal facility. However,

the 2 species of rock nuthatches are an exception—they live on rock faces or buildings. Nuthatches do not use their short, square-ended tail for balance, as woodpeckers (see p.338) and treecreepers (see opposite) do. They have long, sturdy toes and claws, and climb by placing one foot higher than the other, balancing on the lower one. They search the bark for insects and invertebrates but also eat seeds and nuts, cracking these with their bill. They nest in holes in trees or rocks, and a few excavate their own holes in rotten wood. Females lay 4–10 red-spotted, white eggs. Many nuthatch species have blue-gray upperparts, although the 3 South Asian species are blue-green. All species, except for some red-breasted nuthatches, are nonmigratory.



**EURASIAN NUTHATCH**  
Bright slate-blue and orange, *Sitta europaea*, is 4¼–5 in (11–13 cm) long and has a carrying “pee, pee” song. It plasters its nest hole with mud to make the opening smaller. This bird feeds on insects, seeds, and nuts, which it wedges in bark and cracks open with its bill.

**RED-BREASTED NUTHATCH**  
*Sitta canadensis*, 4¼–4¾ in (11–12 cm) long, lives in North American coniferous forests as far north as Alaska and Newfoundland. In winter, it feeds on conifer seeds and, when the harvest fails, moves south in large numbers. It smears pine resin around the nest hole, possibly to keep ants out.

Family Polioptilidae

# Gnatcatchers

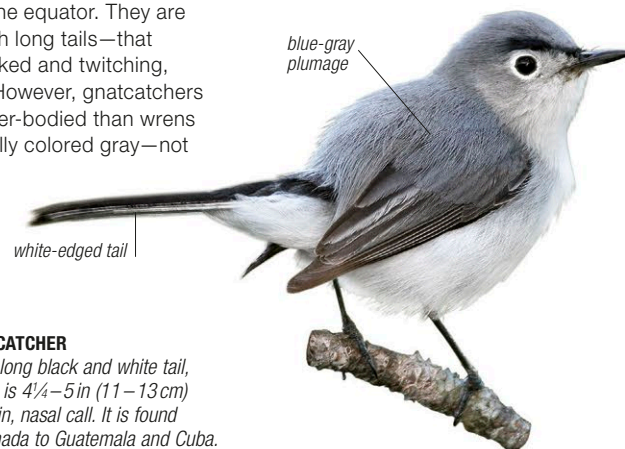
Length 4–5 in (10–13 cm)

Species 18



Formerly classified with Old World warblers, but now known to be more closely related to wrens, the small gnatcatchers are confined to the Americas and reach their greatest diversity near the equator. They are active birds with long tails—that are usually cocked and twitching, wren-fashion. However, gnatcatchers are more slender-bodied than wrens and are generally colored gray—not

brown. Some have black markings on the head. Most species spend much of their time high in trees, where they forage on insects gleaned from foliage; they often accompany other insect-eaters in mixed flocks in order to drive their prey from cover. Their calls and songs are described as thin, but musical. Gnatcatchers build a delicate nest of petals and plant down, bound with spiders’ webs, moss, and lichens, on a horizontal branch. Both sexes incubate the 4–5 eggs.



**BLUE-GRAY GNATCATCHER**  
A gray bird with a long black and white tail, *Polioptila caerulea* is 4¼–5 in (11–13 cm) long, and has a thin, nasal call. It is found from southern Canada to Guatemala and Cuba.

Family Troglodytidae

# Wrens

Length 3¼–9 in (8–22 cm)

Species 88



Apart from one species encircling the Northern Hemisphere—the Eurasian wren—this is an exclusively American family. Until recently, the Eurasian wren was considered a subspecies of the winter wren. Some are forest birds; others live among cacti in deserts. Wrens are generally brown with darker barred or spotted markings; some species have white patches, too. They spend most of their time in dense undergrowth—often close to the ground, but have loud, harsh calls.

Wrens are mostly short-winged, weak fliers; they often have their tail (short in some species, longer in others) cocked over their back. Males build nests in cavities or make domes—depending upon species. Several nests may be constructed, some purposefully used for roosting. The female chooses a nest, which she completes by lining before laying 2–10 eggs. Chicks are either cared for by both parents, or by the female alone; older offspring may act as helpers in raising another brood.



**CACTUS WREN**  
One of the larger wrens, *Campylorhynchus brunneicapillus* is 8 in (20 cm) long, and is found in North America from Nevada to Mexico.

**EURASIAN WREN**  
*Troglodytes troglodytes* is the only wren species that is found outside the Americas. It is 3¼ in (8 cm) long, and is known for its loud, rattling song. In winter, northern birds migrate south.